

Rotarians address Thalassaemia

Kiran Zehra

The Rotary Wall City Thalassaemia Centre, Bhuj is a place of fun for 5-year-old Garva Uday. "Of course the needle prick hurts me, but nurse aunty gives me toys and plays my favourite rhymes too," he says. Every year approximately 100,000 children across the world are born with thalassaemia, of which 10,000 are born in India. "As per the records from the District Health Officer more than 350 cases have been reported in Bhuj district and most of these children are from very poor families," says Rm Amit Chauhan, member of RC Bhuj Wall City, D 3051.

The club has been endorsing thalassaemia awareness as its prime project from its charter year (2006). Thalassaemia is a form of inherited blood disorder where abnormal formation of haemoglobin results in improper oxygen transport and destruction of red blood cells. It can cause complications like iron overload, bone deformities, and cardiovascular disorders. Patients with thalassaemia might need transfusion as frequently as once a week. The cost could be between Rs 750 to 2,000 per unit of blood, making it impossible for the economically weak to afford treatment.

The ward

In 2014, PDG Dr Gyaneshwar Rao, who is also the Medical Director of GAIMS (Gujarat Adani Institute of Medical Science), offered the club an exclusive ward in the Bhuj Civil Hospital for developing a thalassaemia centre. During Navratri 2014, a Dandiya event organised by the club raised Rs 7 lakh that



Baby Garva Uday being treated at the Thalassaemia Centre.

was used in the development of the centre.

On the eve of the Rotary Year 2015-2016 the club inaugurated a state-of-the-art thalassaemia centre for children. The ward is maintained by the medical staff from GAIMS. "We have tried to create a happy atmosphere at the ward. Bright coloured walls, an LED TV, video games, toys, recliner beds ... now attracts even those who were getting treatment from private hospitals," says Chauhan. The staff members

are warm and striking animated conversations with the children, using puppets, is part of their job description. "When you pass by our ward, you will always hear a cackle," says the ward in-charge Neeta Soni.

EEE approach

While the ward is taking care of the children suffering from this severe disorder, the Rotarians have taken it upon themselves to Examine, Explain and Educate the society on thalassaemia. According to the club's inputs from their research over the last 10 years preventive measures at a national level will be cost-effective. The cost of prevention of the disorder is 10 times less compared to the cost of treatment. The need for better strategies and novel interventions to combat thalassaemia is now gaining momentum in our country and RC Bhuj Wall City is happy that they have laid a strong foundation. ■

The cost of prevention of the disorder is 10 times less compared to the cost of treatment.